

Early Money and Committee Seats: Pre-Primary Donors and House Committee Assignments

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Abstract

Do the organized interests that finance a candidate's first, most uncertain campaign end up represented on the committees where that legislator later serves? Using every first-cycle PAC contribution to House members first elected to the 107th through 116th Congresses, I distinguish *seed* interests, which first gave before the member's first successful primary, from *bandwagon* interests, which first gave after it, and link each interest to the committees it targeted before the member arrived. Within member and industry, seed interests are modestly more likely than non-donors to be tied to the member's committees, and their per-interest alignment exceeds a random-assignment benchmark. Seed interests also become tied sooner than bandwagon interests, chiefly on the exclusive committees. The association appears mostly at the first assignment, with no clear evidence that it grows over the career or varies with party conditions. Seed interests also give more, and conditional on contribution amounts the seed-bandwagon difference is no longer distinguishable from zero. Pre-primary financial connections are associated with committee placement, but the design cannot tell whether they reflect shared commitments, influence on members' requests, or party brokerage.

Keywords: committee assignments; campaign finance; early money; interest groups; U.S. House

1 Introduction

Most research on money and committees begins after a legislator is seated. Interest groups give to members of the committees that write the rules they care about (Romer and Snyder, 1994; Kroszner and Stratmann, 1998). They redirect money when members change committees (Powell and Grimmer, 2016; Fourniaies and Hall, 2018). They use contributions to secure the time and attention of committee members (Hall and Wayman, 1990; Esterling, 2007). In this work the committee seat comes first and the money follows.

This paper asks the reverse question. Before a first-time candidate holds any committee seat, a small set of organized interests decide to back them while their nomination is still in doubt (Biersack et al., 1993; Francia et al., 2003; Bonica, 2017; Porter and Steelman, 2023). Do the policy domains of those early backers line up with the committees on which the legislator later serves? If they do, the alignment between members' committee portfolios and the interests that fund them is partly in place before any assignment is made.

The question bears on two literatures. Theories of committee assignment trace assignments to members' requests, which reflect district interests and personal expertise, and to party leaders, who filter those requests (Shepsle, 1978; Shepsle and Weingast, 1987; Krehbiel, 1991; Cox and McCubbins, 1993; Frisch and Kelly, 2006). Those theories usually treat members' policy priorities as given. Early donors are among the few observable traces of a candidate's policy commitments before office. Research on political giving distinguishes donors who invest in future access from donors who reward allies or consume politics (Snyder, 1992; Gordon et al., 2007; Barber, 2016). The primary is where that distinction is sharpest. A PAC that gives before the nomination is settled is backing a candidate who may never hold a seat. A PAC that gives after it is, in most districts, backing the likely winner.

I make three contributions. First, I develop the argument that support given before the primary carries different information from support given after it, and that this difference should appear in committee placement. Second, I build an interest-level design for measuring donor-committee alignment. Each donor interest is compared with interests that did

not give, within the same member and the same industry. Each committee's interests are identified only from giving that predates the member and excludes the member's own donors. A permutation benchmark gives the alignment expected if committee portfolios had been assigned at random within party and cohort. I also show why a member-level summary, whether a member holds any seat tied to any donor, cannot answer the question: it rises mechanically with the length of the donor list. Third, I separate the timing of support from its intensity. The date an interest first gives records when it joined the candidate's coalition, not how much the candidate came to depend on it, and I test whether the results survive accounting for contribution size.

The results support a bounded conclusion. Seed interests are 0.59 percentage points more likely than comparable non-donors to be tied to a member's committees, from a base of 1.1 percent, and this per-interest alignment exceeds the random-assignment benchmark. Seed interests become tied sooner and more often than bandwagon interests, almost entirely through the exclusive committees. The alignment is present at the first assignment, with no clear evidence that it grows with tenure, lengthens committee service, steers transfers, or varies with the party conditions I examine. Conditional on contribution amounts, the seed advantage over non-donors remains in most specifications, while the advantage over bandwagon interests is no longer distinguishable from zero. Alignment at entry is consistent with connections formed before office. The design cannot tell whether those connections reflect shared policy commitments, donors' influence on members' requests, or party brokerage at the first assignment, and I treat the mechanism evidence as suggestive.

2 Theory

2.1 Committee assignments and the problem of new members

Three accounts of House committee assignment dominate the literature. In the distributive account, members seek seats that let them deliver for their constituencies, and the assignment

process largely accommodates those requests (Shepsle, 1978; Weingast and Marshall, 1988). In the informational account, the chamber benefits when members with relevant expertise and moderate preferences staff committees (Krehbiel, 1991). In the partisan account, party steering committees use assignments to reward loyalty and protect the majority’s agenda (Cox and McCubbins, 1993; Frisch and Kelly, 2006). Members’ careers and electoral incentives shape the value of a seat, and members trade up as they accumulate seniority (Katz and Sala, 1996; Groseclose and Stewart, 1998).

All three accounts face the same practical problem with freshmen. A newly elected member has no voting record, little legislative reputation, and preferences that leaders and colleagues must infer. Freshmen submit requests that reflect district economics, prior occupations, and campaign promises (Fenno, 1973; Frisch and Kelly, 2006). Where those priorities come from, and what observers can read from them, is less well understood. The early financial coalition is one of the few public records of what a new member brought into office.

2.2 Why the primary divides donors

Contributions arrive at different stages of a campaign and carry different information. Before the primary, a candidate’s chance of reaching Congress is uncertain. Early money is scarce, it moves future fundraising, and it shapes which candidates remain in the field (Biersack et al., 1993; Bonica, 2017; Porter and Steelman, 2023; Thomsen, 2025). An interest that gives at this stage cannot be buying access to a sitting member, because there is none. If it gives strategically, it is betting on the candidate’s future commitments (Snyder, 1992). If it gives out of affinity, it is rewarding a candidate who already shares its goals (Gordon et al., 2007; Barber, 2016). Either way, the decision rests on what the interest knows about the candidate, often through professional networks, questionnaires, and personal contact (Francia et al., 2003; Bonica, 2017).

The primary resolves most of that uncertainty. In most House districts the nominee of

the favored party is the likely winner, and interests that first give after the primary can condition on that. Their support is closer to the access-seeking behavior documented for incumbents (Romer and Snyder, 1994; Fourniaies and Hall, 2018). I call interests that first gave before the member’s first successful primary *seed* interests and those that first gave after it *bandwagon* interests.

Uncertainty also narrows within the pre-primary period, as the field clears and candidates’ fundraising becomes public. Whether interests that give earliest in the pre-primary window differ from those that give on its eve is therefore a natural secondary question. I examine it separately, but I have no independent evidence about when, within a given race, viability became clear, and I do not build the main argument on a cutoff inside the pre-primary period.

2.3 Timing is not intensity

The first-contribution date measures when an interest entered a candidate’s coalition. It does not measure how much the candidate relied on that interest. A PAC that sends a single small check before the primary is coded as seed, just as one that funds a large share of the early campaign is. If what matters for committee placement is financial dependence rather than timing, seed status could proxy for the size of support, since early backers may also give more. I therefore treat timing and intensity as distinct, and I test whether the results hold after excluding token contributions and after accounting for the amount each interest gave.

2.4 From early money to committee seats

Why might seed interests’ policy domains line up with committee seats? Several channels are possible, and the design can only partly distinguish them.

Pre-office connections. Seed interests may back candidates whose experience, district, or convictions already align with the interest’s policy domain, and those same commitments later shape the member’s committee requests. Seed support may instead shape the requests themselves, as members seek seats relevant to the interests that launched them. Or party leaders may read a freshman’s early coalition as a signal of priorities or fundraising potential when making first assignments (Cann, 2008; Heberlig and Larson, 2012). All three channels operate before or at the first assignment, and all three predict alignment at entry. The data cannot separate them.

Reinforcement over the career. Early support may also create an ongoing relationship that pulls a member toward relevant committees over time (Snyder, 1992). That account predicts alignment that strengthens with tenure, longer service on donor-tied committees, and transfers toward them.

Party conditions. If assignment reflects party brokerage of donor coalitions, alignment should vary with the conditions that shape leaders’ discretion and incentives: majority status, the member’s electoral vulnerability, early leadership PAC support, and party loyalty.

I do not assume early money *causes* assignments. A world in which seed interests merely identify candidates whose committee paths were already set produces the same alignment at entry as a world in which early money shapes those paths. A causal reading would require that, conditional on member, industry, and Congress, the committees a member serves on do not depend on unobserved commitments that also attract seed support. I state that assumption and use the design to measure the association, not to identify an effect.

2.5 Expectations

H1 (Seed alignment).

Seed interests are more likely than non-donor interests to be tied to the committees on which a member serves.

H2 (Seed versus bandwagon).

Seed interests are more likely than bandwagon interests to be tied to those committees.

H3 (High-value committees).

The seed advantage is concentrated on the exclusive committees, where members' requests are most selective and the policy stakes for donors are greatest (Groseclose and Stewart, 1998; Berry and Fowler, 2016).

Beyond these, I ask whether alignment is present at entry or builds over the career, whether it varies with party conditions, whether it exceeds what random assignment of committee portfolios would produce, whether it survives accounting for contribution size, and, as a secondary question, whether it differs by when in the pre-primary window an interest first gave.

3 Data and Measurement

3.1 Members and donors

The sample includes every House member first elected in a regular election to the 107th through 116th Congresses whose first-cycle PAC receipts could be linked: 460 members observed over 1,724 member-terms. Members first elected to the 107th Congress (35 members) enter the sample in their second term and contribute 172 member-terms. Their first term is not observed, because the committee map described below would require the 106th Congress's roster, so they are excluded from the first-term, permutation, and survival analyses. PAC contributions come from Federal Election Commission records (Federal Election Commission, 2026). I aggregate PACs into interests at the sub-industry level of the OpenSecrets classification, so that an interest is a coalition of PACs sharing a policy domain (Francia et al., 2003; OpenSecrets, 2026). Party committees, leadership PACs, joint fundraising committees, law firms, lobbyists, and ideological or single-issue PACs are excluded, because their

giving does not target committee jurisdictions.

For each member, every interest that gave during the first successful campaign is classified by the date of its first contribution relative to the member’s primary. Interests that first gave before the primary are *seed* interests; those that first gave after it are *bandwagon* interests. The median member has 13 seed and 38 bandwagon interests. Every other interest active in that Congress is a *non-donor* for that member and serves as the reference category. Seed interests also give more: the median seed interest gave \$6,000 during the first cycle, against \$2,500 for the median bandwagon interest.

Committee assignments by Congress cover all standing committees, with names harmonized across renamings. Appendix A documents the sources and linkage, and Table A1 reports the sample.

3.2 Which interests belong to which committees

No official crosswalk links organized interests to committees. Following the logic of revealed targeting (Romer and Snyder, 1994; Fourinaies and Hall, 2018), I infer each committee’s interests from where PAC money flows. Two features of the construction address the concern that the map is contaminated by the relationships it is meant to detect.

1. The map for a member serving in Congress t uses only contributions made *before* Congress t began, to members of the committee in Congress $t - 1$.
2. It *excludes* all contributions to the member being evaluated.

For each committee, the five sub-industries giving the most under these restrictions are its tied interests. Appendix B and Table A2 describe the map’s coverage. Appendix E reports results with a looser “lift” map and with a map built from the current Congress’s roster.

3.3 Unit of analysis and outcome

The unit is a member $\times$ interest $\times$ term. The outcome, $Tied_{ijt}$, equals one if member i serves in term t on at least one committee for which interest j is a tied interest.

3.4 Why a member-level summary cannot answer the question

A natural way to summarize alignment is at the member level: does the member sit on any committee tied to at least one of their donors? That summary has a mechanical property that makes it unsuitable for comparing donor types. If each of a member's k donor interests has probability p_j of being tied to one of the member's committees and ties occur independently across interests, the probability that at least one is tied is $1 - \prod_{j=1}^k (1 - p_j)$. That quantity rises quickly in k even when no single interest is favored. Ties are not independent in practice, because a member's few committees serve many interests at once; positive dependence slows the increase but does not remove it. Bandwagon lists are several times longer than seed lists, so the member-level summary favors bandwagon donors and makes alignment look high for both.

Figure 1 illustrates the problem in these data. In their first term, 67.1 percent of members hold a seat tied to at least one seed interest, and 89.4 percent hold a seat tied to at least one bandwagon interest. When bandwagon lists are randomly trimmed to the length of each member's seed list, the bandwagon rate falls to 46.6 percent, well below seed. An equally long random draw of non-donor interests yields 12.9 percent, and randomly reassigning committee portfolios yields 65.6 percent for seed lists. The member-level comparison mostly reflects list length, so the analyses below use the interest-level outcome.

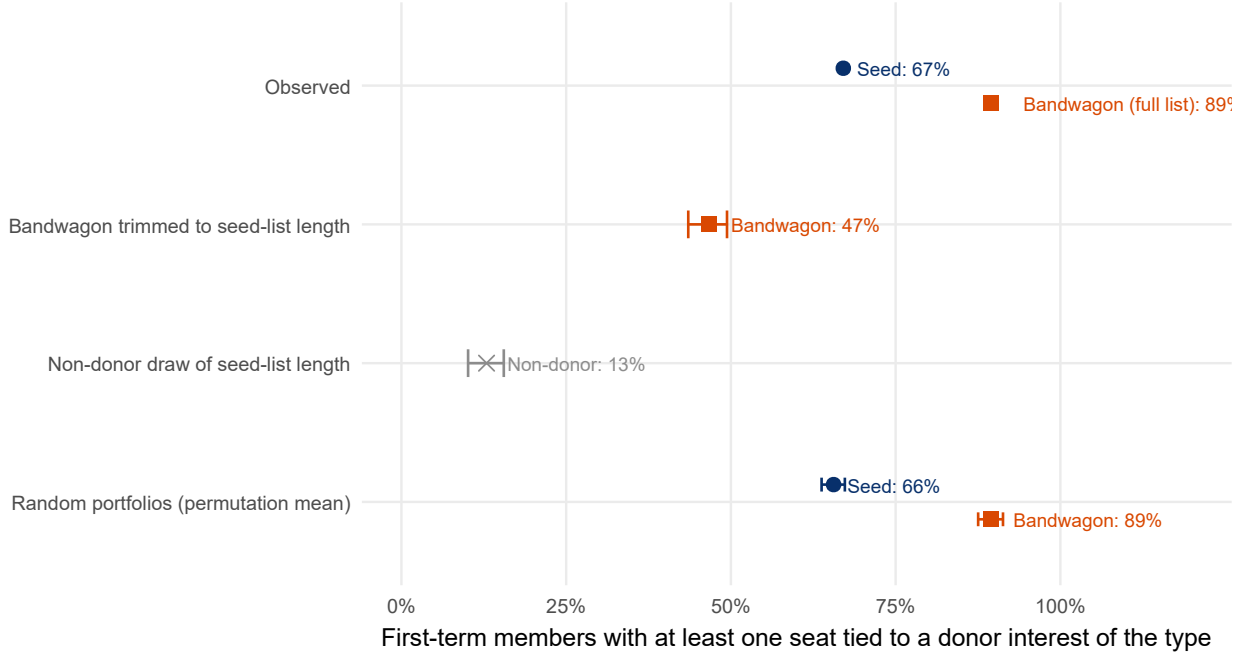


Figure 1: Member-level alignment depends on list length. Share of first-term members holding at least one committee seat tied to a donor interest: seed and bandwagon lists as observed, bandwagon lists trimmed to the length of each member’s seed list, a same-length draw of non-donor interests, and the mean of random reassignments of committee portfolios. Full results in Table A4.

4 Empirical Strategy

The main specification is a linear probability model:

$$Tied_{ijt} = \beta_1 Seed_{ij} + \beta_2 Bandwagon_{ij} + \alpha_{it} + \gamma_{j,c(t)} + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \quad (1)$$

where non-donor interests are the omitted category. The member $\times$ term fixed effects α_{it} compare interests *within the same member’s portfolio in the same term*. That absorbs everything about the member, including district, background, party, seniority, and the number and identity of their committees. The interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects $\gamma_{j,c(t)}$ absorb the fact that some industries, such as banking, health professionals, and real estate, are tied to many committees and give to many members, along with any Congress-specific shifts in an interest’s targeting. The coefficients therefore compare, for example, a bank PAC coalition that backed member i before the primary with the same coalition in the same Congress where it

did not back the member. Standard errors are clustered by member.

Four further analyses complement the regression.

- **Permutation benchmark.** Within each entering cohort and party, I randomly re-assign intact first-term committee portfolios among members and recompute the outcome. The resulting distribution gives the alignment expected if seats were assigned without regard to members’ donors.
- **Survival models.** I model time to the first term in which an interest becomes tied to a member’s committees, using complementary log-log models with member, term, and interest fixed effects. Members who leave the House are censored, which avoids computing match rates only among members still serving.
- **Intensity checks.** I re-estimate the main models excluding interests that gave less than \$1,000 in the first cycle (and \$500 or \$2,500), classifying timing by the date an interest’s cumulative giving first reached \$1,000, and controlling for the amount each interest gave.
- **Multiple testing.** Because the paper tests many contrasts, I adjust p -values with the Benjamini–Hochberg procedure, treating all 224 estimates reported in the paper and appendix as a single family (Benjamini and Hochberg, 1995). Every adjusted p -value in the text and tables refers to this family. 96 estimates pass at an adjusted level of 0.05, 72 of them comparisons with non-donor interests.

5 Results

5.1 Raw alignment by donor type

Figure 2 plots the share of interests tied to a member’s committees by term and donor type. In the first term, 11.1 percent of seed interests are tied to one of the member’s

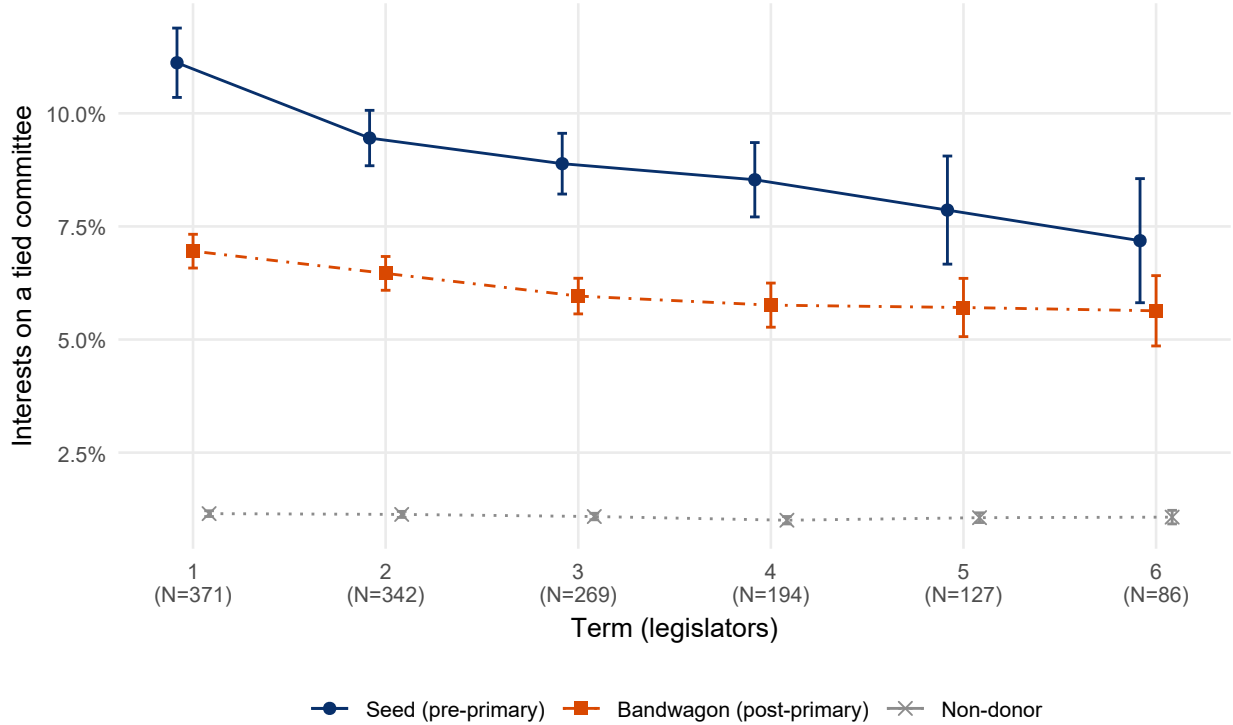


Figure 2: Share of interests tied to a member’s committees, by term and donor type. Leave-one-out, prior-cycle top-five map. Bars are 95% confidence intervals clustered by member. Numbers of members by term are shown below the axis. Full results in Table A3.

committees, compared with 7.0 percent of bandwagon interests and 1.2 percent of non-donor interests. The ordering holds in every term. Much of the raw gap between donors and non-donors reflects which industries give at all: interests that give to House freshmen are disproportionately those with broad committee footprints. The regression models address that composition directly.

5.2 Seed alignment within member and industry

Figure 3 reports estimates of Equation 1. Across all terms, seed interests are 0.59 percentage points (SE 0.19, adjusted $p = 0.008$) more likely than non-donor interests to be tied to the member’s committees, against a non-donor mean of 1.1 percent. Bandwagon interests are 0.30 points (SE 0.11) more likely. In the first term alone the seed estimate is 0.81 (SE 0.24). Using only contributions from 2000 through 2012, it is 0.51 (SE 0.21).

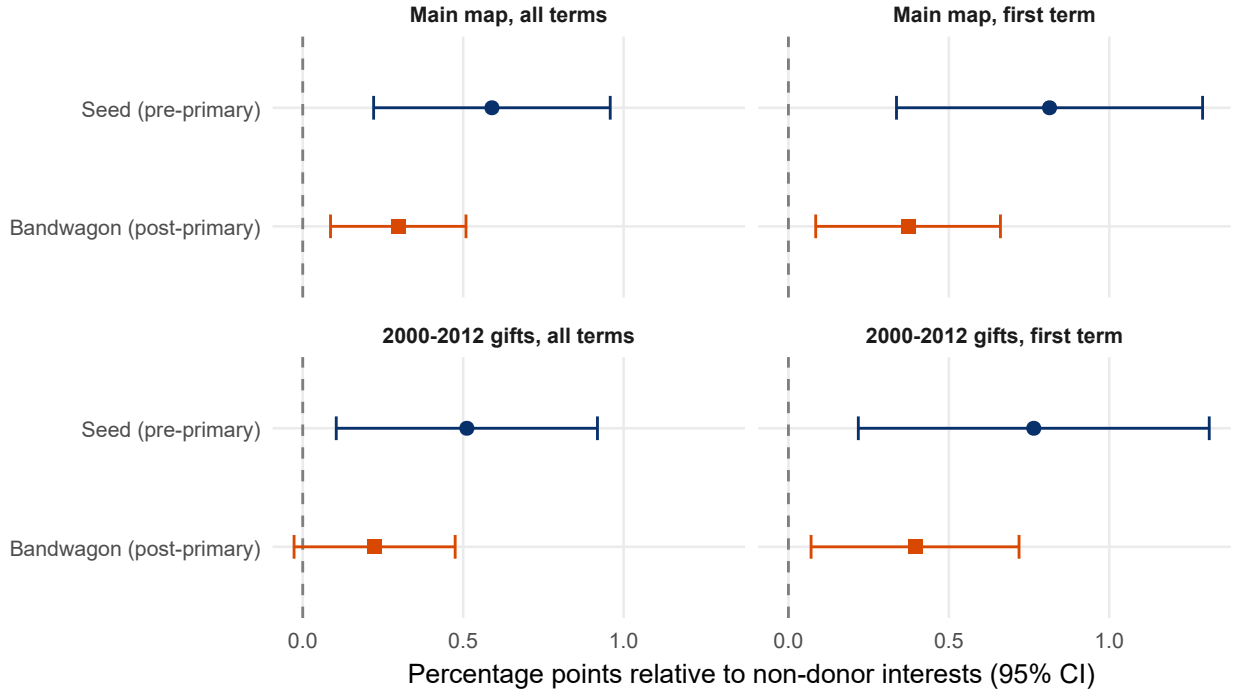


Figure 3: Seed and bandwagon interests relative to non-donors. Coefficients from Equation 1 with member $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects; 95% confidence intervals clustered by member. Panels show all terms and first terms, using all contributions and 2000–2012 contributions only. Full results in Table A6.

These results support H1. Relative to the baseline the association is substantial, about half again the non-donor rate, but in absolute terms it is small. On H2 the regression is less clear. The seed advantage over bandwagon interests is 0.29 points (SE 0.20, adjusted $p = 0.231$), positive but not significant after adjustment. The survival and exclusive-committee analyses below provide the clearer evidence on that comparison.

5.3 Against a random-assignment benchmark

Figure 4 compares observed first-term alignment with the distribution produced by randomly reassigning committee portfolios among same-party members of the same cohort. Per interest, the observed seed rate (11.1 percent) exceeds the permutation mean (10.6 percent), with a permutation p -value of 0.004. The bandwagon rate does not exceed its benchmark ($p = 0.101$). At the member level, whether a member holds at least one seat tied to a seed

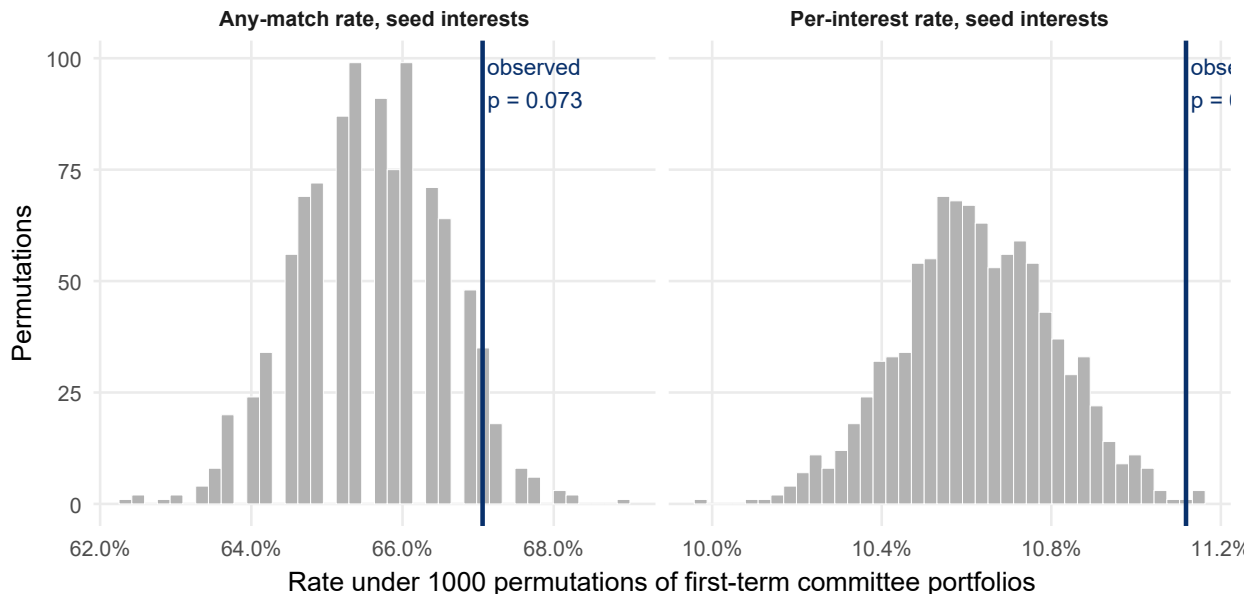


Figure 4: Observed alignment versus random assignment of committee portfolios. Histograms show permutations of intact first-term portfolios within cohort $\times$ party. Vertical lines mark observed values. Left: per-interest rate for seed interests. Right: share of members with at least one seat tied to a seed interest. Full results in Table A5.

interest is not distinguishable from random assignment ($p = 0.073$).

The benchmark is stringent. It holds fixed which interests back which members and asks only whether the seats members received fit those interests better than seats drawn at random from their own party and cohort. Most of the observed alignment is reproduced by assignments that ignore donors, because the industries that back freshmen are tied to many committees. The seed signal is small in absolute terms, but it is distinguishable from chance and the bandwagon signal is not.

5.4 When alignment appears

Figure 5 plots the cumulative share of interests that have become tied to one of the member's committees, with members who leave the House censored. 70 percent of the seed ties that ever occur are in place at the first assignment. By the fifth term, 17.8 percent of seed interests and 12.9 percent of bandwagon interests have been tied at least once. With interest

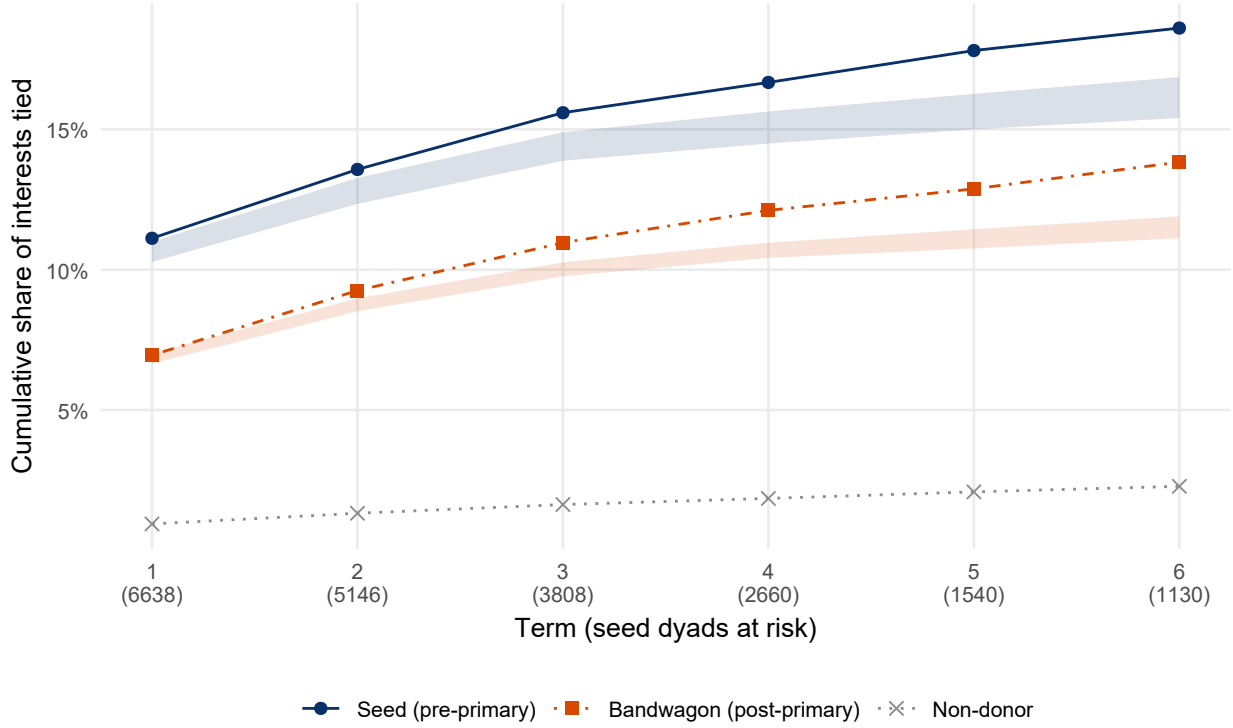


Figure 5: Cumulative share of interests tied to a member’s committees. Members leaving the House are censored. Shaded bands are the 95% range across permutations of committee portfolios carried forward across terms. Full results in Table A7.

fixed effects, the hazard ratio for seed relative to non-donor interests is 1.48 [1.11, 1.98], and relative to bandwagon interests it is 1.25 [1.12, 1.39] (adjusted $p < 0.001$). This is the clearest support for H2.

The seed lead is established at the first term, with no clear widening afterward. Alignment is visible when requests most directly reflect pre-office commitments, and there is little sign that it accumulates with tenure.

5.5 Where alignment appears

Figure 6 splits the outcome by whether the tie runs through an exclusive committee (Appropriations, Energy and Commerce, Financial Services, Rules, and Ways and Means) or through any other committee. The seed advantage runs almost entirely through the exclusive committees: 0.89 points relative to non-donors (SE 0.18, adjusted $p < 0.001$) and 0.80

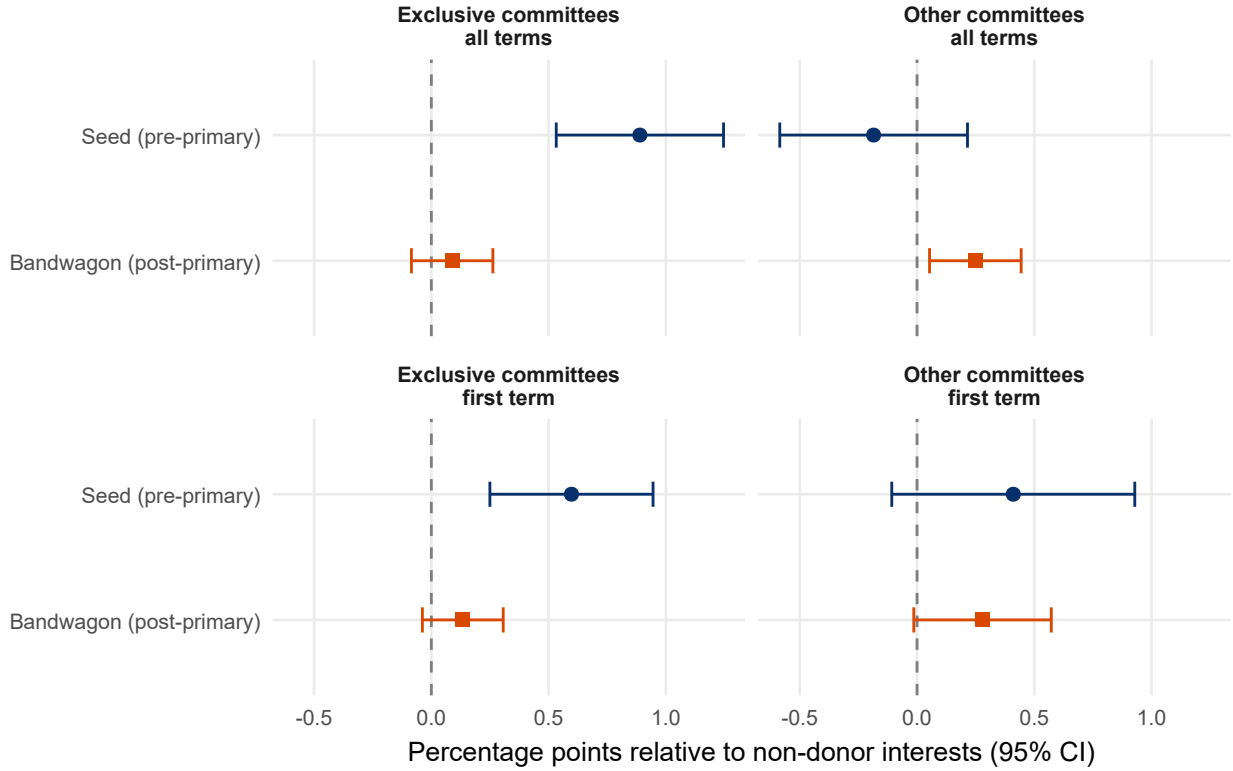


Figure 6: Alignment through exclusive and other committees. Coefficients from Equation 1 with the outcome defined separately for ties through exclusive committees and through all other committees, for all terms and first terms; 95% confidence intervals. Full results in Table A8.

points relative to bandwagon interests (SE 0.22, adjusted $p = 0.002$), against -0.19 (SE 0.20) for the remaining committees. This supports H3.

There are two readings of this concentration. In the first, members' requests for the most valuable seats are their most deliberate, and those requests track the commitments seed interests responded to. In the second, the exclusive committees have broad jurisdictions that overlap with the industries most active in early giving. The interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects absorb each industry's overall propensity to be tied to committees, but not differences in how many industries each committee touches. I read the result as showing that alignment is concentrated where the stakes are highest, not as evidence about who decided those assignments.

5.6 Timing versus intensity

Seed interests give more than bandwagon interests, so seed status could stand in for the size of support. Figure 7 re-estimates the main contrasts under the intensity checks. Token support is uncommon: 5 percent of seed interests and 10 percent of bandwagon interests gave less than \$1,000 in the first cycle. Dropping those interests leaves the seed estimate at 0.62 (SE 0.20) and the survival hazard ratio relative to bandwagon at 1.24. Classifying timing by when an interest's cumulative giving first reached \$1,000, which moves 443 interests from seed to bandwagon, gives 0.71 (SE 0.20) and a hazard ratio of 1.26.

Conditioning on the amount each interest gave changes the picture for H2. With a control for log amount, the seed estimate relative to non-donors remains (0.44, SE 0.18), and amount has its own modest association with alignment (0.29 points per log dollar, SE 0.09). The seed advantage over bandwagon interests, however, shrinks to 0.06 points in the regression and to a hazard ratio of 1.14, neither distinguishable from zero. When amounts enter as quartile indicators instead, the seed estimate relative to non-donors is also no longer distinguishable from zero (0.15, SE 0.21).

These are conditional associations, and they do not show that contribution size explains the timing association. Amount is partly a consequence of timing: an interest that enters before the primary has more time, and more of the campaign, in which to give. Controlling for amount may therefore absorb part of the association that timing produces. What the checks establish is narrower. Seed and bandwagon interests differ both in when they enter and in how much they give, and these data cannot cleanly separate the two.

5.7 Timing within the pre-primary period

As a secondary analysis, I split seed interests into those that first gave in the first three quarters of the window between the candidate's first PAC receipt and the primary (*early seed*) and those that first gave in the final quarter (*late seed*). Figure 8 shows no consistent ordering. Across all terms, early seed interests are 0.79 points (SE 0.23) more likely than

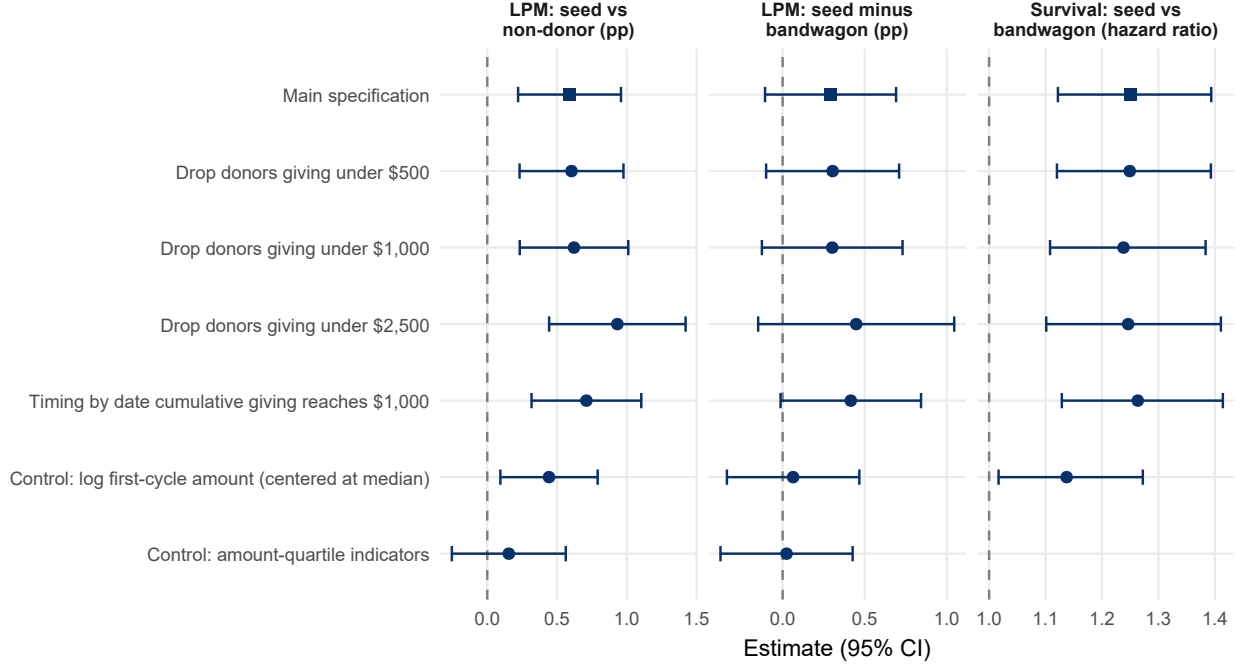


Figure 7: Timing and intensity of support. Seed estimates relative to non-donors, the seed–bandwagon difference, and the seed–bandwagon survival hazard ratio, under the main specification; excluding interests giving less than \$500, \$1,000, or \$2,500 in the first cycle; classifying timing by when cumulative giving reached \$1,000; and controlling for log amount or amount quartiles. 95% confidence intervals. Full results in Table A14.

non-donors to be tied and late seed interests 0.18 (SE 0.28), a difference of 0.61 (SE 0.35). In the first term the order reverses (0.77 versus 0.89). The survival hazard ratio for early relative to late seed is 1.18 ($p = 0.050$). Appendix D reports every quartile and every cutpoint. The few within-window contrasts that pass adjustment run in opposite directions: one survival contrast favors earlier support and one regression contrast favors later support. These contrasts do not rule out differences within the pre-primary period, but they give no consistent support for a cutoff inside it. The main analyses therefore keep the primary, the boundary with a clear theoretical rationale, as the dividing line.

5.8 Party conditions

If party leaders broker donor coalitions into seats, the seed advantage should vary with the conditions that shape leaders’ discretion. Figure 9 interacts seed status with seven such

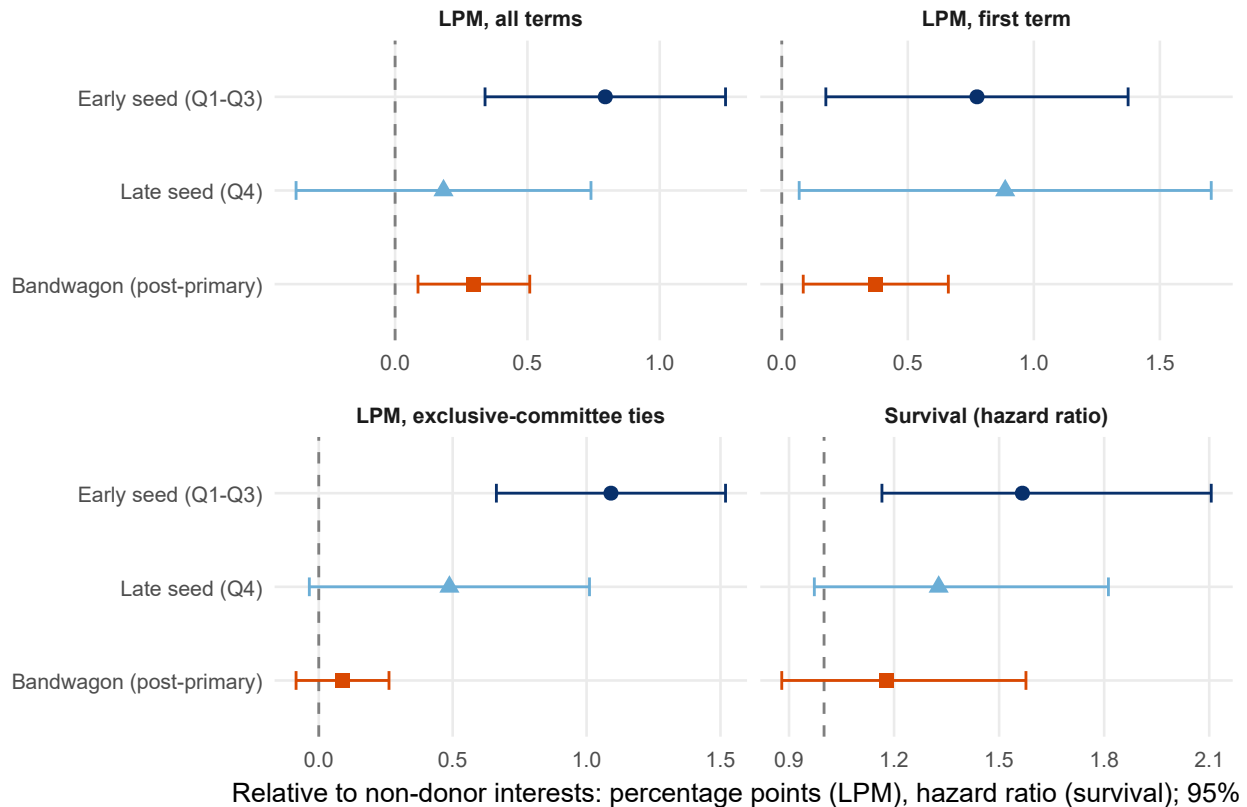


Figure 8: Early seed, late seed, and bandwagon interests relative to non-donors. Early seed interests first gave in the first three quarters of the pre-primary window; late seed interests in the final quarter. Panels show LPM estimates for all terms, first terms, and exclusive committees, and survival hazard ratios. 95% confidence intervals. Full results in Table A10.

conditions:

- majority status, which changes within member across the 2007, 2011, and 2019 transitions in control;
- a competitive first general election;
- entry by open seat rather than by defeating an incumbent;
- defeating a same-party rather than an opposite-party incumbent (34 and 118 members);
- party;
- leadership PAC support during the first campaign;

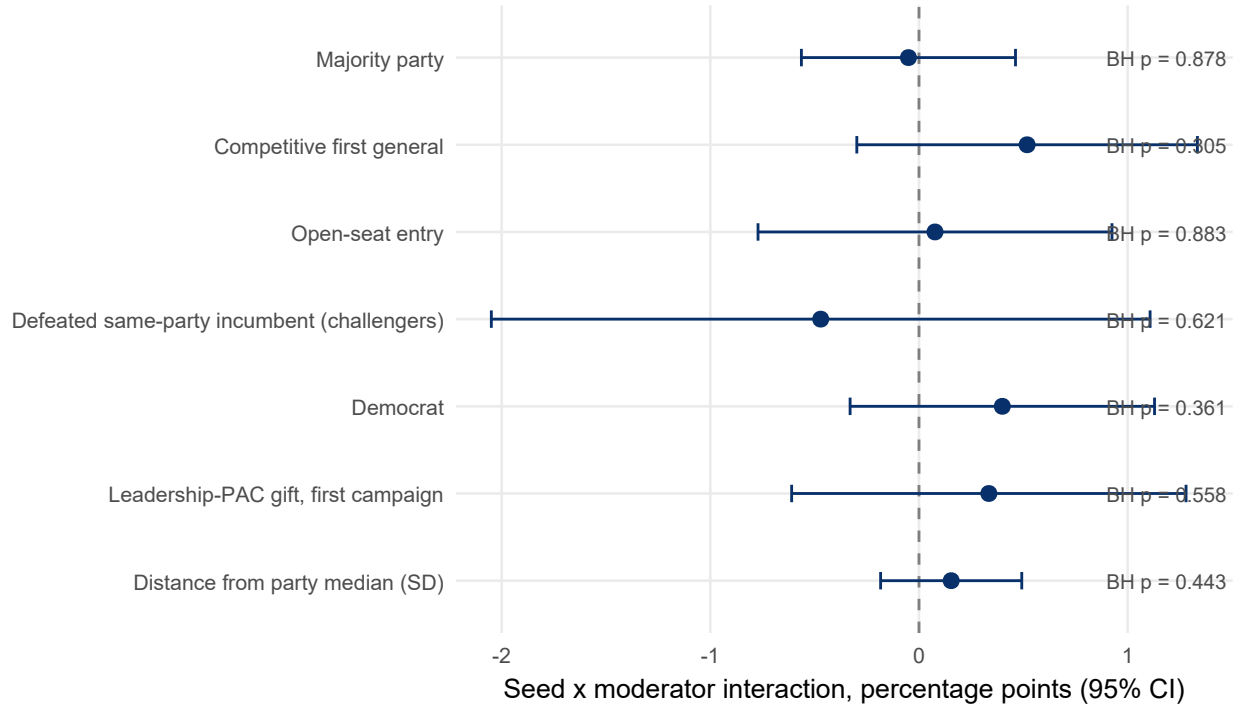


Figure 9: Does the seed advantage depend on party conditions? Interactions between seed status and each moderator in Equation 1; 95% confidence intervals; Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p -values in Table A9.

- distance from the party median on the first DW-NOMINATE dimension (Lewis et al., 2026).

None of these interactions is distinguishable from zero (smallest adjusted $p = 0.305$). The seed advantage is about the same size in both parties and in the majority and the minority. The one party condition that matters works through bandwagon interests: majority members are more likely to hold seats tied to their bandwagon interests (0.63 points, SE 0.15), consistent with a majority party that has more seats to fill on committees where established industries concentrate.

These nulls are limited evidence. They show that the seed association does not depend on the measured conditions, not that party leaders play no role at the first assignment.

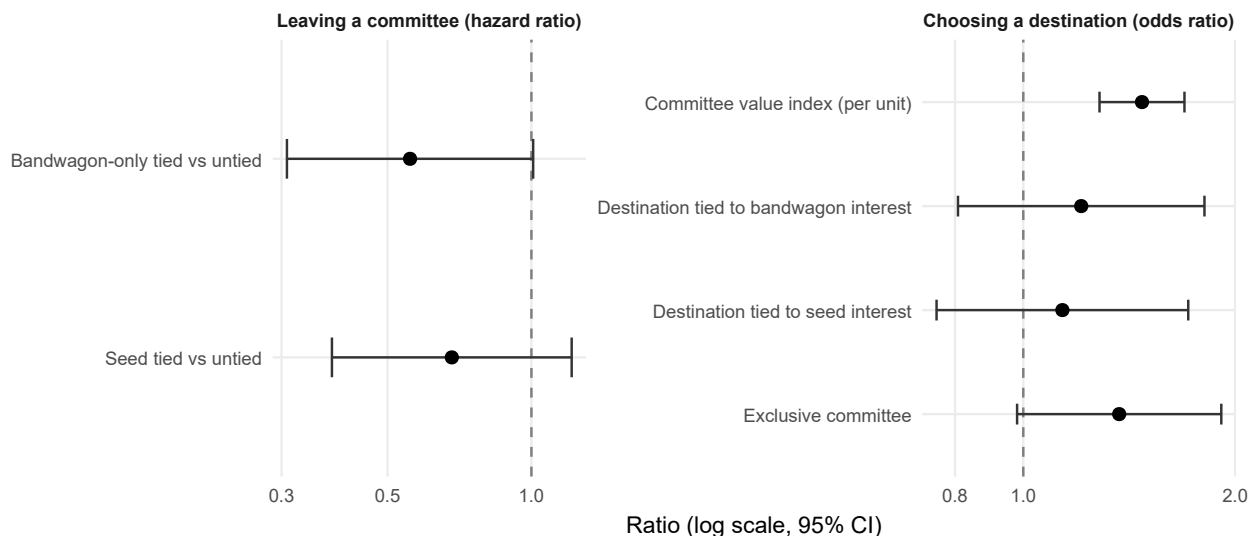


Figure 10: Committee tenure and transfer destinations. Left: hazard ratios for leaving a committee, by the committee’s tie to the member’s donors, from Cox models stratified by member. Right: odds ratios from a conditional logit of transfer destination over all committees available to the member. 95% confidence intervals. Full results in Tables A15 and A16.

5.9 Committee tenure and transfers

If early support creates an ongoing relationship, members should stay longer on committees tied to their seed interests and move toward such committees when they transfer. Figure 10 shows no clear evidence of either pattern. Comparing committee spells within the same member, the hazard of leaving a seed-tied committee is not distinguishable from that of leaving an untied committee (hazard ratio 0.68, 95% CI [0.38, 1.21]), although the interval is wide enough to allow substantial differences in either direction. When members transfer, committee value dominates the choice of destination (odds ratio 1.47 per unit of a Groseclose–Stewart-style value index), with a weaker and imprecise pull toward exclusive committees (odds ratio 1.37). A seed-tied destination adds little (odds ratio 1.14, unadjusted $p = 0.542$).

5.10 Robustness

Appendix E reports the main results with a looser lift-based committee map, a map built from the current rather than the prior Congress’s roster, and contributions from 2000 through

2012 only. The seed advantage over non-donor interests holds across these specifications.

6 Discussion

The evidence supports four conclusions, with different degrees of confidence.

Seed interests are tied to members' committees more often than chance. Interests that back a candidate before the primary are more likely than non-donors to be tied to the committees the member joins, within member and industry, and more likely than random assignment of committee portfolios would produce. The association holds across map constructions, periods, token exclusions, and a control for log contribution amount, but it is not distinguishable from zero when amounts enter as quartile indicators (Table A14). It is small in absolute terms.

The seed–bandwagon difference is sensitive to contribution amounts. Seed interests become tied sooner and more often than bandwagon interests, almost entirely on the exclusive committees. Seed interests also give more, and conditional on amounts the seed–bandwagon difference is no longer distinguishable from zero. Because amount may itself follow from early entry, this does not show that intensity rather than timing drives the difference. The primary divides donors who differ both in when they arrive and in how much they give, and these data cannot cleanly separate the two.

Alignment is present at entry, with no clear evidence that it builds. The association appears at the first assignment, and the career analyses provide no clear evidence that it grows with tenure, lengthens committee service, or steers transfers, although their estimates are imprecise. That pattern is consistent with connections formed before office. It cannot establish whether those connections reflect shared policy commitments, seed interests' influence on members' requests, or party brokerage at the first assignment. The career

results give limited evidence of reinforcement after entry, and the null party interactions give limited evidence against brokerage that depends on the measured conditions.

Member-level summaries mislead. Whether a member holds any seat tied to any donor depends mostly on how many donors they have and how broad those donors' committee footprints are. Comparing interests within members and industries, building maps that exclude the member being studied, and benchmarking against random assignment change what the data appear to show.

Several limitations qualify these conclusions.

- I observe assignments, not requests. Distinguishing the pre-office channels would require members' requests, which are not systematically public for this period (Frisch and Kelly, 2006).
- The committee map is inferred from giving. Even the leave-one-out, prior-cycle construction may tie some interests to committees for reasons other than jurisdiction.
- Interest classifications are coarse, and excluding ideological and single-issue groups removes some donors whose committee stakes are real but diffuse.
- The sample ends with members entering the 116th Congress.

7 Conclusion

Most studies of money and committees ask how interests respond to the committee system. This paper asks whether the interests that launch congressional careers are reflected in it. The answer is a qualified yes. Interests that back candidates before the primary leave a faint but consistent trace on where new members serve, concentrated on the committees that matter most. The trace is in place at entry, with no clear sign that it deepens. Early backers also give more than later ones, and the two features are hard to separate. The

pattern fits connections formed before office better than influence accumulated in it, but which pre-office connection is at work remains an open question that members' committee requests could help answer.

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Supplementary Appendix

A Data and Sample

Members. The sample includes House members first elected in regular elections whose first-cycle PAC receipts could be linked to FEC candidate identifiers. Members are linked across the assignment records, FEC candidate files, and Voteview (Lewis et al., 2026) by FEC identifier, last name, first initial, and state. A link counts only from the member’s entering Congress onward, which prevents parents and children who held the same seat from being merged. Members first elected to the 107th Congress (35 members, 172 member-terms) are included from their second term onward. Their first term is not observed because the leave-one-out map requires the prior Congress’s roster, so they are excluded from the first-term, permutation, and survival analyses.

Contributions. PAC contributions to candidates come from FEC records (Federal Election Commission, 2026), classified into sub-industries using the OpenSecrets taxonomy (OpenSecrets, 2026). Excluded are:

- party committees, leadership PACs, and joint fundraising committees;
- law firms and lobbyists;
- ideological and single-issue PACs (Democratic/liberal, Republican/conservative, and other single-issue categories);
- records that are not contributions, and rows assigned to multiple categories.

Timing. For each member, the first contribution from any PAC in a sub-industry dates that interest’s entry into the coalition. Primary dates for each member’s first successful campaign come from Ballotpedia (Ballotpedia, 2026).

- *Seed* (main analyses): the interest first gave before the member’s first successful primary.
- *Bandwagon* (main analyses): the interest first gave after that primary.
- *Early and late seed* (secondary analysis, Appendix D): seed interests are assigned to quartiles of the window running from the candidate’s first PAC receipt to the primary date. Early seed interests first gave in quartiles 1–3, late seed interests in quartile 4.

Amounts. An interest’s first-cycle amount is the sum of all contributions from PACs in that sub-industry to the member during the first successful campaign. These amounts are used only in the intensity checks (Appendix F).

Committee assignments. Assignments to standing committees by Congress come from the House committee rosters published by the Office of the Clerk (Office of the Clerk, U.S. House of Representatives, 2024). Committee names are harmonized across renamings. Select committees, the Intelligence Committee, and the Ethics Committee are excluded from the committee map because PAC giving rarely targets them.

Table A1: Sample: legislators and legislator-term $\times$ interest observations by Congress

Congress	Legislators	Freshmen	Seed	Bandwagon	Non-donor
108	83	48	2,096	3,451	24,001
109	111	34	2,417	4,900	32,199
110	143	47	3,117	5,688	42,103
111	179	52	3,330	7,354	53,040
112	211	77	3,445	8,798	62,873
113	244	66	3,684	9,894	73,286
114	262	50	3,833	10,661	78,778
115	275	43	4,093	10,879	82,928
116	216	8	3,181	8,383	65,332
Total	460	425	29,196	70,008	514,540

Notes: Legislators are House members who entered in the 107th Congress or later and whose first-cycle PAC receipts are observed; the main map starts in the 108th Congress because it is built from the prior Congress’s roster. Interest columns count legislator-term $\times$ subindustry rows. Seed: the interest’s first gift came before the member’s first successful primary; bandwagon: first gift after the primary; non-donor: every other subindustry that gave to any member in the sample.

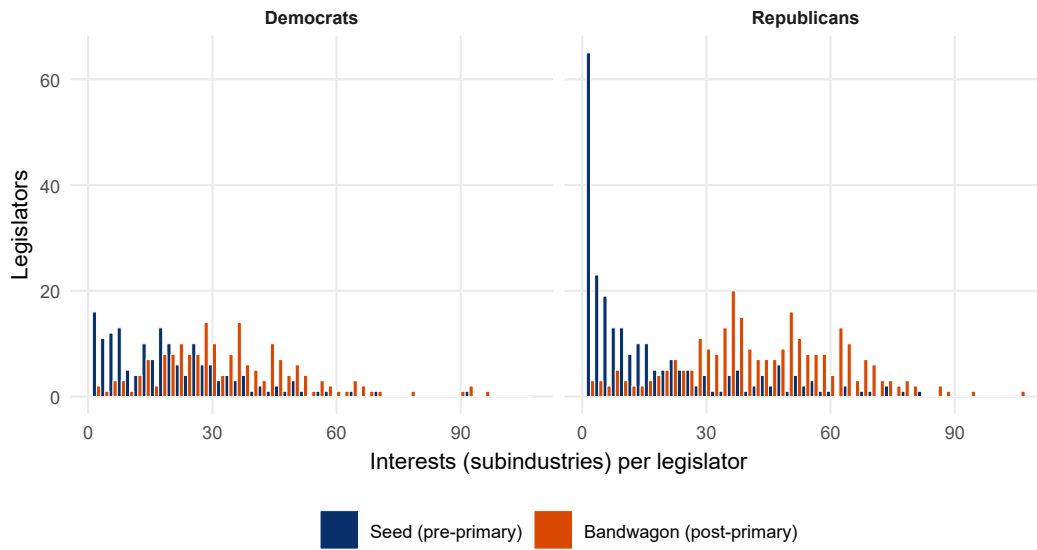


Figure A1: Number of seed and bandwagon interests per member, by party.

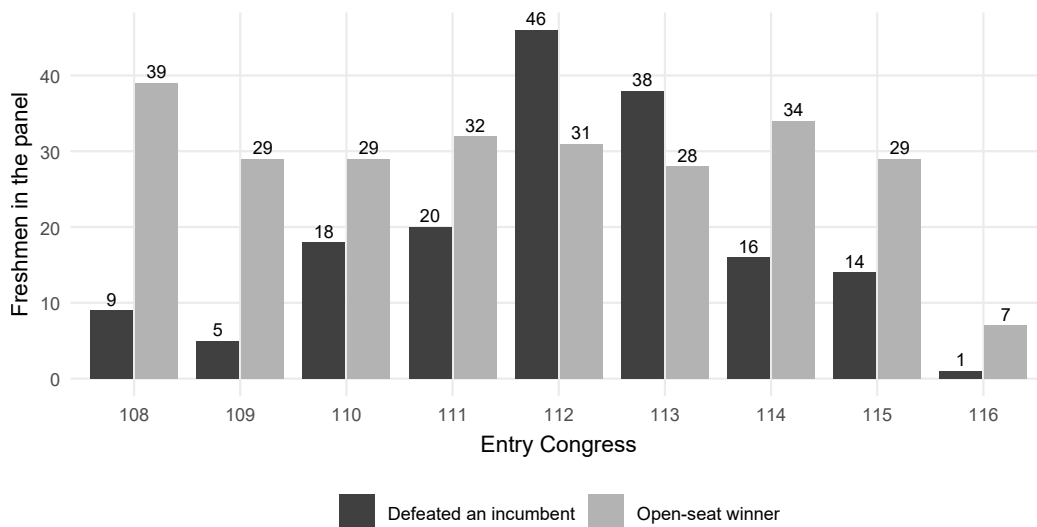


Figure A2: Entering members by route to office (open seat or defeated incumbent) and Congress.

B The Committee–Interest Map

For a member serving in Congress t , committee c ’s tied interests are the five sub-industries with the largest total contributions, during election cycles completed before Congress t began, to the members of c in Congress $t - 1$. All contributions to the member being evaluated are excluded. The two cycles linked to each Congress are pooled. The same exclusions as in Appendix A apply.

Two properties of the map are worth noting. First, a small number of industries are tied to many committees. Health professionals, commercial banks, insurance, and real estate appear in many committees’ top five, which is why the interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects in the main specification are essential. Second, most sub-industries that give to freshmen are never among any committee’s top five. They contribute to the non-donor and donor denominators but can never be tied.

Table A2: Committee–interest maps: construction and coverage

	Main map	Lift map	2000–2012 gifts	Current roster
Congresses	108-116	108-116	108-113	107-116
Member-terms	1,724	1,724	971	1,761
Committee slots mapped	3,437 / 3,438	3,437 / 3,438	2,073 / 2,074	3,541 / 3,541
Committee lists	169	169	112	188
Median list length	5	39	5	5
Member subindustries ever listed	47 / 356	340 / 356	38 / 356	48 / 356

Notes: For legislator i in Congress t , committee c ’s list is built from PAC gifts in the two election cycles before t began, to members of c (prior-Congress roster in the main map), leaving out gifts to i . Main map: top five subindustries, prior-Congress roster, gifts 1998–2018. Lift map: subindustries whose share of giving to the committee is at least 1.5 times the committee’s share of members. 2000–2012 gifts: main construction with gifts from those cycles only. Current roster: membership in Congress t rather than $t - 1$. Standing committees except Intelligence and Ethics. Gifts exclude party, leadership and joint-candidate committees, ideological PACs, lawyers and lobbyists, non-contributions and multi-category records: \$638M of \$3785M excluded.

C Main Results: Full Tables

Table A3: Per-interest match rate by term and interest type

Term	Rate	95% CI	Legislator-terms	Observations
<i>Seed (pre-primary)</i>				
1	0.111	[0.104, 0.119]	371	6,638
2	0.095	[0.088, 0.101]	342	6,569
3	0.089	[0.082, 0.096]	269	5,120
4	0.085	[0.077, 0.094]	194	3,739
5	0.079	[0.067, 0.091]	127	2,417
6	0.072	[0.058, 0.086]	86	1,865
<i>Bandwagon (post-primary)</i>				
1	0.070	[0.066, 0.073]	421	16,784
2	0.065	[0.061, 0.068]	386	15,584
3	0.060	[0.056, 0.064]	302	12,466
4	0.058	[0.053, 0.062]	220	9,323
5	0.057	[0.051, 0.064]	143	5,992
6	0.056	[0.049, 0.064]	97	4,064
<i>Non-donor</i>				
1	0.012	[0.011, 0.012]	425	127,878
2	0.011	[0.011, 0.012]	390	116,687
3	0.011	[0.010, 0.012]	306	91,350
4	0.010	[0.009, 0.011]	223	66,326
5	0.011	[0.010, 0.012]	144	42,855
6	0.011	[0.009, 0.012]	98	28,959

Notes: Share of a legislator's interests of each type that appear on the list of at least one of the legislator's committees in that term (main map). Confidence intervals clustered by legislator.

Table A4: Any-match rates: observed, equalized bandwagon and non-donor placebo

Term	Any-match	95% interval
<i>Seed, observed</i>		
1	0.671	
3	0.614	
5	0.597	
<i>Bandwagon, observed (full list)</i>		
1	0.894	
3	0.882	
5	0.861	
<i>Bandwagon drawn to seed-list length</i>		
1	0.466	[0.435, 0.494]
3	0.435	[0.399, 0.474]
5	0.399	[0.347, 0.451]
<i>Non-donor drawn to seed-list length</i>		
1	0.129	[0.101, 0.155]
3	0.125	[0.092, 0.157]
5	0.124	[0.076, 0.167]

Notes: Share of legislators in the term with at least one interest of the type on a tied committee. Equalized and placebo rows draw, for each legislator, as many bandwagon (or non-donor) interests as the legislator has seed interests; 1000 draws; intervals are the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles. Legislators without interests of a type count as zero.

Table A5: Observed first-term alignment versus random assignment of committee portfolios

Interest type	Observed	Permutation mean	95% range	p	BH p
<i>Per-interest rate</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.111	0.106	[0.103, 0.110]	0.004	0.015
Bandwagon (post-primary)	0.070	0.068	[0.066, 0.070]	0.101	0.166
<i>Any-match rate</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.671	0.656	[0.638, 0.673]	0.073	0.129
Bandwagon (post-primary)	0.894	0.895	[0.875, 0.913]	0.587	0.645

Notes: Freshmen in the main panel (425 members). Intact first-term committee portfolios are permuted among freshmen of the same entering Congress and party, 1000 times. p is the share of permutations at least as large as the observed value (one-sided); BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A6: Per-interest linear probability models: seed and bandwagon interests relative to non-donor interests

	Main map, all terms	Main map, first term	2000-2012 gifts, all terms	2000-2012 gifts, first term
Seed (pre-primary)	0.59 (0.19)*	0.81 (0.24)*	0.51 (0.21)*	0.76 (0.28)*
Bandwagon	0.30 (0.11)*	0.37 (0.15)*	0.22 (0.13)	0.39 (0.17)*
Seed – bandwagon	0.29 (0.20)	0.44 (0.28)	0.29 (0.22)	0.37 (0.32)
Non-donor mean (%)	1.11	1.15	1.09	1.11
Observations	613,744	151,300	345,676	115,344
Legislators	460	425	359	324

Notes: Entries are percentage-point differences in the probability that the interest is on the list of one of the legislator’s committees, with standard errors clustered by legislator in parentheses. All models include legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects. The seed – bandwagon row is a linear combination of the two coefficients. * Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted $p < 0.05$, adjusting across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A7: Time to a committee tie: discrete-time and Cox hazard models

	Hazard ratio	95% CI	p	BH p	Person-terms
<i>Cloglog: legislator, term and interest FE (main)</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	1.48	[1.11, 1.98]	0.008	0.025	26,963
Seed – bandwagon	1.25	[1.12, 1.39]	0.001	0.001	26,963
Bandwagon	1.18	[0.88, 1.59]	0.258	0.350	26,963
<i>Cloglog: legislator and term FE</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	9.80	[7.60, 12.63]	0.001	0.001	104,740
Seed – bandwagon	1.76	[1.61, 1.93]	0.001	0.001	104,740
Bandwagon	5.56	[4.31, 7.17]	0.001	0.001	104,740
<i>Cloglog: term FE</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	9.68	[7.51, 12.47]	0.001	0.001	104,752
Seed – bandwagon	1.46	[1.35, 1.57]	0.001	0.001	104,752
Bandwagon	6.65	[5.17, 8.55]	0.001	0.001	104,752
<i>Cox, stratified by legislator</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	9.69	[7.52, 12.48]	0.001	0.001	104,752
Seed – bandwagon	1.75	[1.60, 1.92]	0.001	0.001	104,752
Bandwagon	5.53	[4.29, 7.12]	0.001	0.001	104,752

Notes: Member $\times$ interest dyads at risk from the member’s first term; leaving the House is censoring. Hazard ratios relative to non-donor interests (contrasts are ratios between types). Non-donor interests are 20 random draws per member sized like the member’s seed set; estimates are averaged over draws with between-draw variance added. Standard errors clustered by legislator. BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A8: Ties through exclusive and other committees

	Estimate (pp)	SE	p	BH p	Non-donor mean (%)
<i>Exclusive committees, all terms</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.89	0.18	0.001	0.001	0.28
Seed – bandwagon	0.80	0.22	0.001	0.002	0.28
Bandwagon	0.09	0.09	0.317	0.390	0.28
<i>Exclusive committees, first term</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.60	0.18	0.001	0.004	0.16
Seed – bandwagon	0.46	0.21	0.026	0.058	0.16
Bandwagon	0.13	0.09	0.128	0.199	0.16
<i>Exclusive committees, members holding an exclusive seat</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.49	0.20	0.017	0.040	0.61
Seed – bandwagon	0.39	0.25	0.112	0.181	0.61
Bandwagon	0.10	0.13	0.456	0.531	0.61
<i>Other committees, all terms</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	-0.19	0.20	0.365	0.437	0.87
Seed – bandwagon	-0.43	0.24	0.067	0.121	0.87
Bandwagon	0.25	0.10	0.013	0.034	0.87
<i>Other committees, first term</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.41	0.26	0.121	0.193	1.03
Seed – bandwagon	0.13	0.30	0.665	0.727	1.03
Bandwagon	0.28	0.15	0.063	0.115	1.03

Notes: Outcome: the interest is on the list of one of the member’s exclusive committees (Appropriations, Energy and Commerce, Financial Services, Rules, Ways and Means), or of one of the member’s other committees. Legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects; standard errors clustered by legislator. BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A9: Do party and electoral conditions moderate alignment?

Interaction with	Estimate (pp)	SE	p	BH p	Legislators
<i>Majority party</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	-0.05	0.26	0.847	0.878	460
Bandwagon	0.63	0.15	0.001	0.001	460
<i>Competitive first general</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.52	0.42	0.214	0.305	453
Bandwagon	0.08	0.22	0.707	0.765	453
<i>Open-seat entry</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.08	0.43	0.859	0.883	460
Bandwagon	-0.26	0.23	0.262	0.351	460
<i>Defeated same-party incumbent (challengers)</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	-0.47	0.81	0.560	0.621	158
Bandwagon	-0.48	0.44	0.268	0.355	158
<i>Democrat</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.40	0.37	0.284	0.361	460
Bandwagon	-0.16	0.23	0.487	0.558	460
<i>Leadership-PAC gift, first campaign</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.33	0.48	0.488	0.558	323
Bandwagon	0.25	0.28	0.363	0.437	323
<i>Distance from party median (SD)</i>					
Seed (pre-primary)	0.15	0.17	0.371	0.443	460
Bandwagon	0.09	0.10	0.380	0.450	460

Notes: Each block is one model adding interactions between the interest-type indicators and the moderator; legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects absorb the moderator's main effect. Same-party challenger: the incumbent holding the district in the prior Congress (Voteview) belonged to the member's party; estimated among members who defeated an incumbent. Distance from the party median is standardized. BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

D Timing of Seed Support

The main analyses divide donors at the primary. This appendix reports the secondary analysis of timing within the pre-primary window. Table A10 gives the early (quartiles 1–3) versus late (quartile 4) split shown in Figure 8 in the main text. Figure A3 and Table A11 report every quartile separately, and Figure A4 and Table A12 report all three possible early/late cutpoints. The quartile-3 cutpoint shown in the main text was chosen after the quartile estimates were examined, so it should be regarded as exploratory.

Two patterns stand out.

- Each quartile’s estimate relative to non-donor interests is reported in Table A11; there is no monotone gradient across quartiles.
- Across the three cutpoints, the early–late contrasts that pass adjustment run in opposite directions. Splitting at the midpoint, a survival contrast favors earlier support (smallest adjusted $p = 0.031$); separating the first quartile, a regression contrast favors later support.

The within-window estimates do not rule out differences, but they give no consistent support for an alternative cutoff. The paper therefore uses the primary as its dividing line and makes no claim that alignment increases with how early a donor gave.

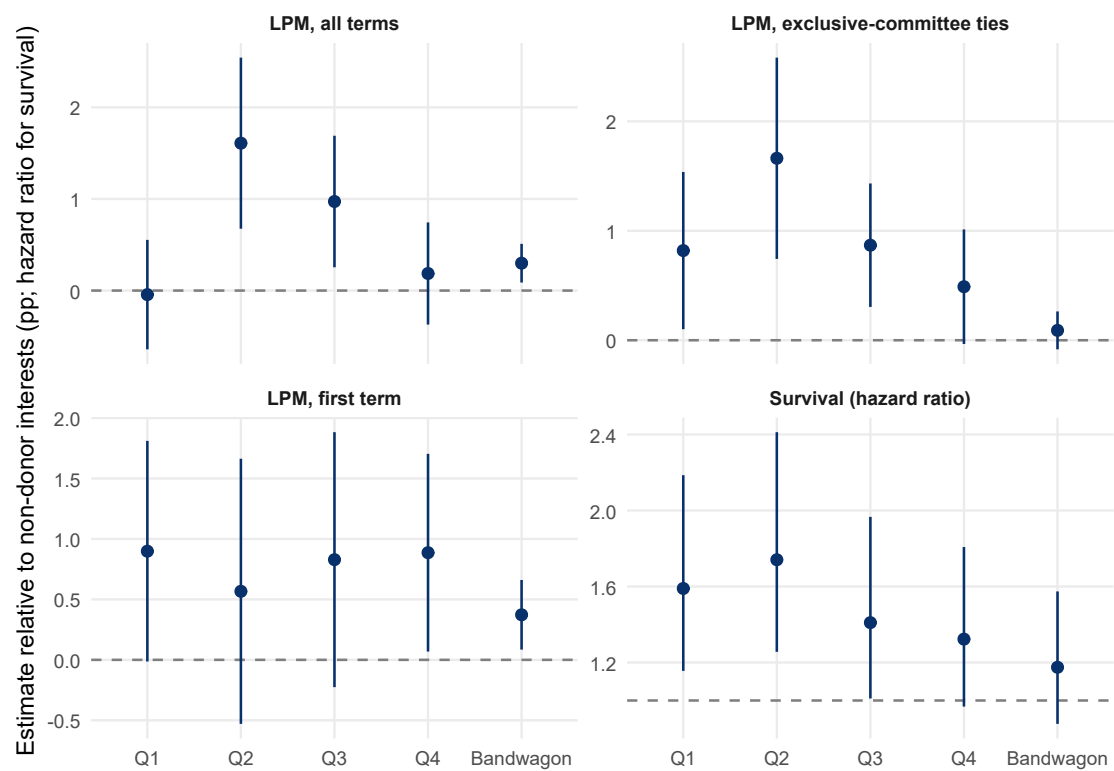


Figure A3: Estimates by pre-primary quartile of first contribution (Q1 = earliest), relative to non-donors.

Table A10: Seed interests split by timing: early (first three quarters of the pre-primary window) versus late (final quarter)

	Estimate	SE	p	BH p
<i>LPM, all terms</i>				
Early seed (Q1–Q3)	0.79	0.23	0.001	0.004
Late seed (Q4)	0.18	0.28	0.520	0.585
Bandwagon	0.30	0.11	0.006	0.020
Early – late	0.61	0.35	0.079	0.136
Early – bandwagon	0.50	0.24	0.042	0.086
Late – bandwagon	-0.11	0.29	0.697	0.758
<i>LPM, first term</i>				
Early seed (Q1–Q3)	0.77	0.31	0.012	0.032
Late seed (Q4)	0.89	0.42	0.034	0.072
Bandwagon	0.37	0.15	0.011	0.031
Early – late	-0.11	0.52	0.831	0.870
Early – bandwagon	0.40	0.33	0.229	0.321
Late – bandwagon	0.51	0.44	0.248	0.343
<i>LPM, exclusive-committee ties</i>				
Early seed (Q1–Q3)	1.09	0.22	0.001	0.001
Late seed (Q4)	0.49	0.27	0.068	0.121
Bandwagon	0.09	0.09	0.317	0.390
Early – late	0.60	0.32	0.060	0.112
Early – bandwagon	1.00	0.25	0.001	0.001
Late – bandwagon	0.40	0.29	0.168	0.249
<i>Survival (log hazard ratio)</i>				
Early seed (Q1–Q3)	1.57	0.151	0.003	0.012
Late seed (Q4)	1.33	0.159	0.075	0.131
Bandwagon	1.18	0.149	0.273	0.359
Early – late	1.18	0.084	0.050	0.098
Early – bandwagon	1.33	0.063	0.001	0.001
Late – bandwagon	1.13	0.078	0.123	0.193

Notes: Same specifications as the main analysis with the seed indicator split in two. LPM rows: percentage points relative to non-donor interests (legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects). Survival rows: hazard ratios with legislator, term and interest fixed effects (SE on the log scale). The cutpoint was chosen after the quartile estimates were inspected (Tables A11 and A12). BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A11: Seed interests by pre-primary quartile of first contribution

	Estimate	SE	p	BH p
<i>LPM, all terms</i>				
Seed Q1 (earliest)	-0.04	0.30	0.885	0.901
Seed Q2	1.61	0.48	0.001	0.004
Seed Q3	0.97	0.37	0.008	0.025
Seed Q4	0.19	0.28	0.513	0.580
Bandwagon	0.30	0.11	0.006	0.020
Q1 – Q4	-0.23	0.41	0.572	0.631
Q1 – bandwagon	-0.34	0.32	0.282	0.361
Linear trend, Q1 to Q4	0.01	0.14	0.968	0.973
<i>LPM, first term</i>				
Seed Q1 (earliest)	0.90	0.47	0.054	0.104
Seed Q2	0.57	0.56	0.312	0.390
Seed Q3	0.83	0.54	0.124	0.195
Seed Q4	0.89	0.42	0.034	0.072
Bandwagon	0.37	0.15	0.012	0.031
Q1 – Q4	0.01	0.67	0.985	0.985
Q1 – bandwagon	0.53	0.48	0.278	0.359
Linear trend, Q1 to Q4	0.02	0.21	0.914	0.922
<i>LPM, exclusive-committee ties</i>				
Seed Q1 (earliest)	0.82	0.37	0.026	0.058
Seed Q2	1.66	0.47	0.001	0.003
Seed Q3	0.87	0.29	0.003	0.011
Seed Q4	0.49	0.27	0.068	0.121
Bandwagon	0.09	0.09	0.309	0.390
Q1 – Q4	0.33	0.46	0.469	0.541
Q1 – bandwagon	0.73	0.38	0.056	0.107
Linear trend, Q1 to Q4	-0.18	0.15	0.227	0.319
<i>Survival (log hazard ratio)</i>				
Seed Q1 (earliest)	1.59	0.163	0.004	0.016
Seed Q2	1.74	0.166	0.001	0.004
Seed Q3	1.41	0.170	0.043	0.087
Seed Q4	1.32	0.159	0.079	0.136
Bandwagon	1.17	0.149	0.280	0.361
Q1 – Q4	1.20	0.109	0.091	0.151
Q1 – bandwagon	1.35	0.091	0.001	0.004
Linear trend, Q1 to Q4	0.93	0.034	0.026	0.059

Notes: Quartiles of the window from the candidate’s first PAC receipt to the primary date (Q1 earliest). LPM rows: percentage points relative to non-donor interests (legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects). Survival rows: hazard ratios with legislator, term and interest fixed effects (SE on the log scale). Exploratory; BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A12: All three early/late splits of seed interests

Model		Estimate	SE	<i>p</i>	BH <i>p</i>
<i>Q1 — Q2-Q4</i>					
LPM, all terms	Early seed	-0.06	0.30	0.851	0.878
LPM, all terms	Late seed	0.80	0.22	0.001	0.002
LPM, all terms	Early — late	-0.86	0.36	0.018	0.041
LPM, all terms	Early — bandwagon	-0.36	0.32	0.265	0.353
LPM, first term	Early seed	0.90	0.46	0.053	0.104
LPM, first term	Late seed	0.79	0.30	0.010	0.029
LPM, first term	Early — late	0.12	0.59	0.844	0.878
LPM, first term	Early — bandwagon	0.53	0.48	0.274	0.359
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early seed	0.81	0.37	0.028	0.061
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Late seed	0.92	0.21	0.001	0.001
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early — late	-0.11	0.43	0.802	0.848
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early — bandwagon	0.72	0.38	0.060	0.112
Survival (log hazard ratio)	Early seed	1.58	0.163	0.005	0.017
Survival (log hazard ratio)	Late seed	1.45	0.152	0.015	0.036
Survival (log hazard ratio)	Early — late	1.09	0.097	0.351	0.428
Survival (log hazard ratio)	Early — bandwagon	1.34	0.091	0.001	0.006
<i>Q1-Q2 — Q3-Q4</i>					
LPM, all terms	Early seed	0.71	0.28	0.012	0.032
LPM, all terms	Late seed	0.50	0.24	0.038	0.077
LPM, all terms	Early — late	0.21	0.35	0.551	0.615
LPM, all terms	Early — bandwagon	0.41	0.29	0.159	0.240
LPM, first term	Early seed	0.75	0.36	0.036	0.075
LPM, first term	Late seed	0.86	0.32	0.008	0.024
LPM, first term	Early — late	-0.12	0.47	0.801	0.848
LPM, first term	Early — bandwagon	0.37	0.38	0.331	0.405
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early seed	1.20	0.28	0.001	0.001
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Late seed	0.64	0.22	0.004	0.016
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early — late	0.56	0.35	0.109	0.179
LPM, exclusive-committee ties	Early — bandwagon	1.11	0.31	0.001	0.002

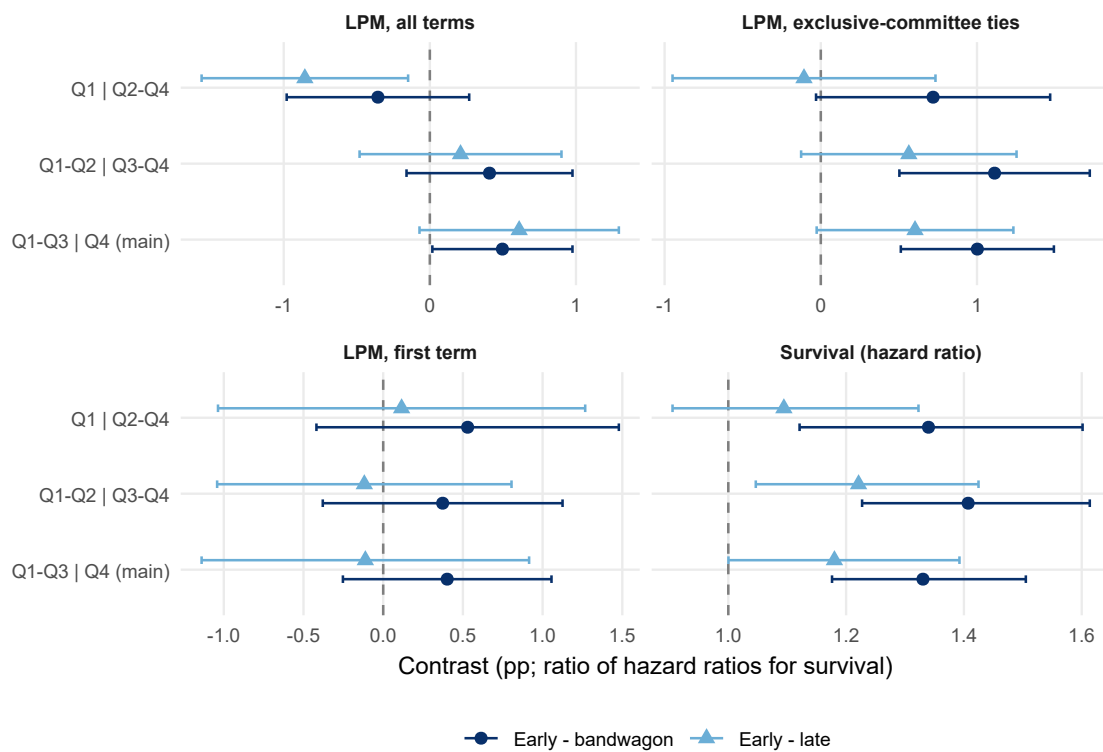


Figure A4: Early-seed estimates under the three possible early/late cutpoints.

E Robustness

Table A13 re-estimates the main models under three alternatives.

- *Lift map.* Interest j is tied to committee c when j 's share of giving to c 's members is at least 1.5 times c 's share of House members. The interest must give at least \$25,000 in total, and the committee must have at least three linked members. This map ties many more interests to each committee and discriminates less sharply.
- *Current-roster map.* The map is built from contributions made before Congress t to members of committee c in Congress t rather than $t - 1$.
- *2000–2012 contributions only.* This removes any reliance on contribution data for later cycles.

Table A13: Main results under alternative committee–interest maps

Sample		Estimate (pp)	SE	p	BH p
<i>Main: top 5, prior roster</i>					
All terms	Seed (pre-primary)	0.59	0.19	0.002	0.008
All terms	Seed – bandwagon	0.29	0.20	0.152	0.231
All terms	Bandwagon	0.30	0.11	0.006	0.020
First term	Seed (pre-primary)	0.81	0.24	0.001	0.004
First term	Seed – bandwagon	0.44	0.28	0.117	0.187
First term	Bandwagon	0.37	0.15	0.011	0.031
Term-1 per-interest rates	Seed 0.111; bandwagon 0.070; non-donor 0.012				
<i>Lift map, prior roster</i>					
All terms	Seed (pre-primary)	5.18	0.83	0.001	0.001
All terms	Seed – bandwagon	2.48	0.75	0.001	0.005
All terms	Bandwagon	2.70	0.42	0.001	0.001
First term	Seed (pre-primary)	4.14	0.69	0.001	0.001
First term	Seed – bandwagon	1.16	0.66	0.080	0.136
First term	Bandwagon	2.98	0.41	0.001	0.001
Term-1 per-interest rates	Seed 0.208; bandwagon 0.204; non-donor 0.216				
<i>Top 5, current roster</i>					
All terms	Seed (pre-primary)	0.59	0.20	0.003	0.011
All terms	Seed – bandwagon	0.35	0.20	0.081	0.136
All terms	Bandwagon	0.24	0.10	0.016	0.040
First term	Seed (pre-primary)	0.32	0.24	0.177	0.261
First term	Seed – bandwagon	-0.06	0.26	0.803	0.848
First term	Bandwagon	0.38	0.14	0.005	0.017
Term-1 per-interest rates	Seed 0.106; bandwagon 0.066; non-donor 0.012				
<i>Top 5, prior roster, 2000–2012 gifts</i>					
All terms	Seed (pre-primary)	0.51	0.21	0.014	0.036
All terms	Seed – bandwagon	0.29	0.22	0.195	0.282
All terms	Bandwagon	0.22	0.13	0.081	0.136
First term	Seed (pre-primary)	0.76	0.28	0.006	0.021
First term	Seed – bandwagon	0.37	0.32	0.254	0.347
First term	Bandwagon	0.39	0.17	0.018	0.041
Term-1 per-interest rates	Seed 0.114; bandwagon 0.070; non-donor 0.011				

Notes: Linear probability models with legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects; percentage points relative to non-donor interests; standard errors clustered by legislator. The lift map ties an interest to a committee when its share of giving to the committee’s members is at least 1.5 times the committee’s share of House members. The current-roster map uses committee membership in Congress t rather than $t - 1$ (and so keeps the 107th Congress). The 2000–2012 map uses only gifts from those cycles. BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

F Timing and Intensity of Support

The seed–bandwagon classification records when an interest entered a member’s coalition, not how much it gave. Table A14 re-estimates the main contrasts under the following alternatives.

- *Token exclusions.* Interests whose first-cycle giving to the member totals less than \$500, \$1,000, or \$2,500 are dropped. Under the \$1,000 threshold, 5 percent of seed and 10 percent of bandwagon interests are excluded.
- *Cumulative timing.* An interest is classified as seed only if its cumulative giving to the member reached \$1,000 before the primary. This moves 443 interests from seed to bandwagon; no interest can move the other way.
- *Amount controls.* The log of the first-cycle amount, or indicators for amount quartiles, are added to Equation 1. Amount terms are set to zero for non-donor interests. The log amount is centered at the median donor amount, so the log model’s seed coefficient is evaluated at that median; the quartile model’s seed coefficient is evaluated at the lowest amount quartile.

Seed and bandwagon status is computed directly from the contribution records and the primary dates: an interest is seed if its first positive, dated contribution precedes the state primary, and a contribution on primary day counts as bandwagon. As a check, this coding agrees with an independently constructed coding for 99.4 percent of the 21,596 member–interest pairs both cover; most of the 124 disagreements arise from differences in source files for the 2014 and 2016 cycles.

Table A14: Timing of entry versus intensity of support

Specification	Seed vs non-donor (pp)	Seed – bandwagon (pp)	Exclusive ties: seed (pp)	HR, seed vs bandwagon
Main specification	0.59 (0.19)*	0.29 (0.20)	0.89 (0.18)*	1.25* [1.12, 1.39]
Drop donors under \$500	0.60 (0.19)*	0.30 (0.21)	0.90 (0.18)*	1.25* [1.12, 1.39]
Drop donors under \$1,000	0.62 (0.20)*	0.30 (0.22)	0.92 (0.19)*	1.24* [1.11, 1.38]
Drop donors under \$2,500	0.93 (0.25)*	0.45 (0.30)	1.28 (0.25)*	1.25* [1.10, 1.41]
Timing at cumulative \$1,000	0.71 (0.20)*	0.42 (0.22)	1.02 (0.21)*	1.26* [1.13, 1.41]
Log-amount control	0.44 (0.18)*	0.06 (0.21)	0.74 (0.17)*	1.14 [1.02, 1.27]
Amount-quartile control	0.15 (0.21)	0.02 (0.21)	0.46 (0.20)	

Notes: Columns 2–4: percentage points relative to non-donor interests (legislator $\times$ term and interest $\times$ Congress fixed effects; SE clustered by legislator). Column 5: hazard ratio (seed relative to bandwagon) from discrete-time cloglog models with legislator, term and interest fixed effects, averaged over 5 non-donor draws. Token-donor rows drop donor interests whose first-cycle giving to the member falls below the threshold (they are removed, not recoded as non-donors). The cumulative-\$1,000 row dates an interest's entry by the day its cumulative first-cycle giving reached \$1,000 and drops interests that never did. Amount controls are zero for non-donors; the log amount is centered at the median donor amount (\$2,500), and the quartile model's seed coefficient refers to the lowest amount quartile. Amount coefficients: log dollars 0.29 (0.09); top quartile 0.87 (0.30). Seed and bandwagon are coded from the same gift records and primary dates used here, so the cumulative rule can only move interests from seed to bandwagon. * Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted $p < 0.05$ across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family); main-specification rows repeat Tables A6–A8.

G Committee Tenure and Transfers

Committee spells are member $\times$ committee sequences of consecutive terms. A spell ends when the member leaves the committee while remaining in the House. Spells are censored when the member leaves the House. The committee value index is built from whole-House transfers between the 107th and 116th Congresses following Groseclose and Stewart (1998). The destination model is a conditional logit over all standing committees on which the transferring member did not already serve.

Table A15: Committee tenure: hazard of leaving a committee by the committee’s tie to the member’s donors

Spell tied to	Hazard ratio (exit)	95% CI	p	BH p	N
<i>Cox, stratified by member (committee and start-Congress effects)</i>					
Bandwagon-only tied	0.56	[0.31, 1.01]	0.053	0.104	1,522
Seed tied	0.68	[0.38, 1.21]	0.193	0.282	1,522
<i>Cox, stratified by committee (between members)</i>					
Bandwagon-only tied	0.86	[0.59, 1.25]	0.425	0.501	1,522
Seed tied	0.97	[0.66, 1.42]	0.873	0.893	1,522
<i>Discrete-time cloglog (member and committee $\times$ Congress FE)</i>					
Bandwagon-only tied	0.38	[0.14, 1.02]	0.054	0.104	2,223
Seed tied	0.70	[0.24, 2.04]	0.510	0.580	2,223

Notes: Reference: spells on committees not tied to any of the member’s donor interests. 1522 spells (Untied: 71; Bandwagon-only tied: 541; Seed tied: 910); 683 end with the member leaving the committee while in the House. Hazard ratios below one mean longer spells. Standard errors clustered by member; BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).

Table A16: Transfer destinations and committee values

	Odds ratio	95% CI	<i>p</i>	BH <i>p</i>
<i>A. Destination choice: Donor ties only</i>				
Destination tied to seed interest	0.95	[0.62, 1.46]	0.807	0.849
Destination tied to bandwagon interest	1.39	[0.92, 2.08]	0.115	0.185
<i>A. Destination choice: Donor ties, exclusive status and committee value</i>				
Destination tied to seed interest	1.14	[0.75, 1.72]	0.542	0.607
Destination tied to bandwagon interest	1.21	[0.81, 1.81]	0.357	0.432
Exclusive committee	1.37	[0.98, 1.91]	0.066	0.119
Committee value index (per unit)	1.47	[1.28, 1.69]	0.001	0.001
<i>B. Committee value index (Bradley–Terry; Small Business = 0)</i>				
Ways Means	3.41			
Energy Commerce	3.28			
Appropriations	3.03			
Administration	2.50			
Armed Services	1.52			
Financial Services	1.42			
Judiciary	1.32			
Foreign Affairs	1.20			
Homeland Security	1.20			
Budget	1.06			
Transportation	1.05			
Infrastructure				
Rules	0.95			
Oversight	0.66			
Agriculture	0.40			
Education	0.36			
Natural Resources	0.34			
Science	0.00			
Small Business	0.00			
Veterans Affairs	-0.06			

Notes: Panel A: conditional logit over the map committees the member did not hold in the prior term; 263 transfers by panel members. Panel B: value index from a Bradley–Terry model of 819 whole-House transfers (member leaves one committee and joins another between consecutive Congresses), 107th–116th Congresses; the column reports the index, not an odds ratio. BH: Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted *p* across all estimates reported in the paper and appendix (one family).